

FABLE III



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Fable III has been released two years after the series made its debut on the Xbox 360 with Fable 2. While this may ordinarily seem like a reasonable amount of time to develop a sequel on a familiar platform; apparently the ambitions of Peter Molyneux need longer development time to be realized.

Fable in troubled times

There are a few noteworthy improvements and most pre-release promises are kept. The sad thing is that some of the most crucial game mechanics are broken to the point of being frustrating. The golden trail leading to the next objective often behaves erratically and at times disappears completely. Hero's companion dog's AI behavior has become worse from what it was, when it was first introduced in Fable II. The dog often lags behind the player, becomes unresponsive and at times even points at treasures that are not there. These flaws are especially annoying because with the removal of mini-map, the golden trail and the dog have become the most crucial navigational helpers.

Now coming to couple of the most touted new addition to the series—the hand-holding gesture. Its execution leaves a lot to be desired with broken animation and erratic behavior, while adding little value to game-play.

While the concept of weapons changing appearance and properties according to usage may be exciting, it is apparently easier said than done. There are two main categories of weapons in Fable III—one set that the player inherits from the Hero of Fable II and others are categorized as legendary weapons. I played through almost

the entire game without ever using the Hero weapons. Yet the weapons would change appearance and properties each time relevant fighting skill was upgraded. In my opinion, this is just a cheeky hack to give the impression that the weapon morphing system works as it should. The legendary weapon morphing works better, but this is only because each of these weapons has fixed set of objectives that needs to be achieved in order to unlock upgrades.

Saving grace

Fortunately, Fable III has enough goodness to rescue it from certain oblivion. Lionhead Studio has assembled the most impressive coterie of British comic talent with the likes of John Cleese, Stephen Fry, Bernard Hill and Ben Kingsley. Together they deliver the most witty and well written script that the series has seen so far. Especially the character of Reaver, played by Stephen Fry is a memorable one.

While the game's main-quest is all a bit too familiar and disappointing, some of the side-quests are quite brilliant. The way in which the main-quest moves towards its conclusion is almost exactly like in Fable II. At certain points during the main-quest however, the game allows the player to take their time with free-roaming. This is when Fable III really shines on back of some well thought of side-quests—with a twisted sense of humor—reminding us why we love the series so much.

Pros

- Brilliant script and voice-acting
- Improved load-times
- Fairly impressive collection of weapons
- Great side-quests

Cons

- Some essential game-systems are broken
- Frame-rate drops
- Short and underwhelming main quest
- Often plays like an unfinished product

Verdict

• An otherwise disheartening game is rescued by dry British wit delivered by top actors, and complimented by some awesome side-quests



After having spent over 40 hours with Fable III, we can't help but think that the game would have been far more enjoyable if the developers had taken more time to iron out some core issues. However, even as it stands, Fable III has enough going for it to make it a fairly enjoyable experience. **d**